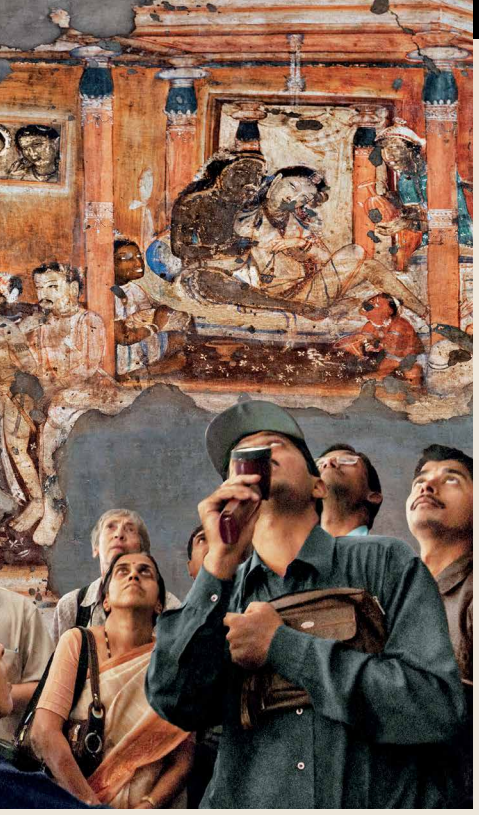


NATURALLY LIT
A wall painting in the verandah outside Cave 17

ecosystem of rock-cut caves is opening out a whole fascinating Jataka in modern research. Geographically, Ajanta stands at the crossroads of the ancient trade routes Uttarapatha and Dakshinapatha. Take that as a metaphor on all counts. It is a bridge to a dimly-seen continent, a whole dynamic aesthetic universe, all of ancient India as a work of art being born over a millennium.

Come to religion, and you see Buddhism inscribed here in two discrete stages of its evolution in India—from the early days of the spartan, aniconic stupa, where the Buddha is not depicted directly, to his fully realised human form seven centuries later, accompanied by the whole teeming Mahayana pantheon of parallel deities like the bodhisattvas. Ajanta captures that inner movement, from austere dhrupad to exuberant khayal, as it were, all in one place. Weave in Ellora, and a morphology of Hinduism too appears, magically, as if from a photographic negative.

Consider two vital elements. The first is architectural: the Cave. Right from the expressions of "prehistoric spirituality" at Bhimbetka or thousands of other parietal art sites, the Cave is a special place of exaltation, an inherent sacredness. It's that strange awe the Buddhist grottos recreate. Joining a two-century-long train of the enchanted, the artist in Raghu Rai responded to it intuitively. "Most Ajanta photography has been flat, two-dimensional, documentary visuals. I wanted to recreate the feel of being inside a cave," says the ace photographer, who's doing a book on the subject. Through a series of transformations in plain sight at Ellora, that's the schema absorbed by Hinduism—the garbhagriha, the inner sanctum of Hindu temples, is nothing but a metaphoric cave, resymbolised as the cosmic womb.

An optical game next: pause on the figure of the stupa, and look next at the lingam...an epiphanic shiver! They are isomorphic, the same shape. A genetic transfer again? Think of Shiva as conceived within classical Saivism, the ascetic aloof from the world, or pure consciousness...more Buddha echoes. Take also that near-identical sculptural cluster: the Buddha surrounded by angelic nagas, and Shiva's familiar retinue. Ajanta's vision of eternity is thus also one of a moment in transition.

AJANTA IS UNIQUE AS SYMBOL AND SUBSTANCE. IT IS THE "MOTHER LODE OF ANCIENT ASIAN ART"

If art holds vital clues on two major world religions, it's also intertwined with a third strand: political history. Here, again, Ajanta is a bridge—between Ancient and Medieval, deemed conventionally to begin in 500 AD. Why was the site abandoned around 480 AD? How do we arrive at that date anyway? Walter Spink, the Michigan historian who first came to Ajanta in 1953 and last in 2019—sculpting his scholarly life around decades of finical research—read a series of tiny clues adding up to a provocative big picture. His 'Short Chronology' holds that all of Ajanta's later phase—25 or so caves, with their murals—were done within a tight frame, between 460–480 AD, not over centuries. The idea of a full Renaissance being squeezed into two decades was controversial, but has been grudgingly accepted by most scholars worldwide. Spink also claimed centrality in Indian history for a dynasty most lay people would not have heard of—the Vakatakas. Harisena, under whose patronage Ajanta bloomed, was "the greatest king in India, possibly in the entire world, at this time", he writes, and "it is under the Vakatakas, not the Guptas, that India's Golden Age reaches its apogee".

A remarkable claim, one that would call for a substantial revision of accepted history. In Romila Thapar's magisterial *Early India* (2002), Ajanta's patron dynasty makes an unassuming entry on page 228 with the sentence: "The Vakatakas were the next to dominate the northern Deccan." Harisena, as Spink rues, is not even mentioned. Not all historians endorse his claim, based on an Ajanta inscription, that Harisena controlled India coast to coast, but a blueprint for a new, more granular history is being written as we speak—those like Hans T. Bakker are nudging the Vakatakas closer centrestage. Rajesh Kumar Singh, working on an encyclopaedia of Buddhist rock-cut caves, advances another fascinating thesis on the final riddle about Ajanta: its dramatic collapse. From evidence of design evolution, he deduces that the grammar of shrine architecture at Ajanta was transformed mid-way through its second phase by a sudden influx of artists from Bactria and Gandhara, fleeing the Hunnic wars. This is not mere Buddhist esoterica: we are perchance witnessing the birth of the Hindu *garbhagriha* itself, with an invisible Gandharan inscription across its heart. Others are looking at the ethnic richness depicted on Ajanta's walls, including, clearly, 'foreigners'. Who were they? Was that really the 'Persian embassy' in that mural? Why does a bird decoration on a silver bowl in Swat look exactly like the one on a Cave 1 ceiling panel? A whole ghost-world of answers resides within those fading pigment puzzles, waiting to be exorcised. ■